

Early Blight



⚠ **Note :** Our AI helps quickly identify plant diseases, but it isn't 100% accurate. Results depend heavily on image quality—blurry photos can confuse the model. Always verify the final diagnosis with a qualified plant expert..

About disease and the symptoms

Early blight is a fungal disease. It is most commonly caused by the fungus *Alternaria solani*. Despite the name 'early' blight, it actually tends to show up on older, mature foliage first, usually right around the time the plant starts producing fruit.

This fungus survives the winter in the soil on old plant debris. When it rains or when you water your garden, the soil splashes up onto the lowest leaves, bringing the fungus with it. It absolutely loves warm temperatures and high humidity or heavy morning dews!

Early blight has a very distinct look that makes it much easier to identify once you know what to search for:

Starts Low: The first signs almost always appear on the older, lower leaves closest to the soil.

The 'Target' Pattern: The most classic, unmistakable symptom is dark brown or black spots that develop concentric rings. If you look closely, the spots look just like a tiny target or bullseye!

Yellowing: As the spots grow larger, the leaf tissue immediately surrounding them often turns yellow.

Leaf Drop: Over time, the heavily infected leaves will dry up, turn completely brown, and fall off the plant. This is dangerous because it leaves the plant's fruit exposed to the hot sun (which can cause sunscald).

Treatment

Treating early blight is all about managing the fungus and keeping it from splashing back up onto your healthy leaves! **First**, carefully prune off and throw away those infected lower leaves (don't put them in your compost!) so the disease can't easily climb further up the plant. **Next**, lay down a thick layer of organic mulch, like straw or wood chips, around the base of the plant to create a protective barrier that stops fungal spores in the dirt from splashing up when it rains. Just like with bacterial spots, you'll want to water at the soil level to keep the leaves perfectly dry. Finally, if the spots are spreading quickly, applying a protective fungicide (like an organic copper spray or chlorothalonil) will help shield the remaining healthy foliage from the fungus.

